

the screen treatment is literally faithful to the original. Next to *Coriolanus*, *Caesar* is perhaps the least "poetic" of the dramatist's efforts outside the field of comedy. His text here employs none of the exuberant romantic imagery of the earlier *Romeo and Juliet*, none of the turbulence of *Lear* or the darkness of *Macbeth*, and certainly none of the oriental splendor of another play about Roman history, *Antony and Cleopatra*. The literary values of *Caesar* are intellectual and thoughtful, rather than splendid and imaginative. They are analytical rather than suggestive. They are values determined by the play's primary concern with political ideas, and by its primary interest in characters involved in political situations. If the film version, for all its meticulous reproduction of ancient Rome, seems prosaic rather than poetic in appeal, the main responsibility rests with Shakespeare himself.

Julius Caesar stands as one of Shakespeare's earlier efforts in the most demanding field of dramatic composition—tragedy. In *Hamlet*, *Othello*, *Lear*, *Macbeth*, and *Antony and Cleopatra* he was subsequently to go much further in his mastery of the form. In *Caesar*, the strengths that he was to develop and the weaknesses that he was to overcome are both apparent. And in faithfully heeding Hamlet's admonition to "speak the speech as I pronounc'd it," the film version is characterized by strengths and weaknesses alike.

Julius Caesar: The Role of the Technical Adviser

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THERE ARE CLICHÉS and standard anecdotes about all categories of people in the film world, even about such a transient and marginal one as the "technical adviser" or "expert." The more obvious and banal stories have to do with money and are based on the common notion that the intellectuals' ranks from which experts are recruited are underpaid, whereas film salaries are high. The episodes that I have heard on the subject range all the way from the one about the producer of a historical motion picture who hired a professor as a period expert and, on offering to pay a certain figure, found that the professor understood it as a monthly salary while he himself had intended it, of course, as a weekly one; to the one about the medical expert who was summoned from a university to work as consultant on a tricky murder situation in a film, and after asking whether he might charge his "usual fee," mentioned a very substantial figure as his "daily" one. From then on, the story continues, he was highly respected by his temporary employers, put up in a splendid hotel suite, fetched by a studio Cadillac every morning, and so on.

The most significant stories, however, concern the actual work of an "expert." And they add up to the general idea that a "technical adviser" will be asked to produce detailed information in his field, that he will even be given an office and a stenographer at the studio, and that finally no use at all will be made of his expert advice.¹ This is the cliché. How completely inaccurate it is I can-

¹ Cf. Hortense Powdermaker, *Hollywood, the Dream Factory*, Boston, 1950, p. 27: "The position of the 'expert' who is called in for temporary consultation on a picture is frequently like that of the artist. He is usually paid a high fee, and then very little or no attention is paid to his opinion."